Tears pinched her eyes as she turned to Léa. But her sister was staring at their escort, tugging Rose's sleeve.

"Hurry up," Léa said. "Can't you see he's getting cross?"

Rose didn't want to leave without one more look so that she would remember the painting always. Letting go of her sister's hand, she took a few steps back. She let her gaze glide from the parents watching as their son said goodbye to his wife, holding their child in his arms, to an older man at the other end of the track, a bouquet in his hand, pointing to the ground. The painter must have been evoking the Great War and the fate of millions of men going east to fight the Germans. The irony of it all happening again.

"Rose," Léa shouted, "the train is going to leave."

Rose hurried over to Léa, her hand trembling as she gave her identity papers to a French police officer.

"Quickly," the officer said. "Your train is on platform twelve and departs in six minutes." He returned their tickets and papers. "If you miss it, you'll have to sleep on the platform until the next train in the morning." He waved them forward as more passengers pressed to board. Cupping his hands, he called, "Berlin train, platform twelve, five minutes to depart."

"Come on, Rose," Léa said, gently pulling her sister toward the train that would take them far from France.

Rose followed, though part of her was still with the painting in the hall. She remembered the book that Virginie had shown her, where she'd seen similar muted blues and browns in the paintings of the Old Masters. Had Herter chosen blue as a warning to dissuade those going to war against a neighbor again? She wrapped her arms around her waist, haunted by all those lives lost, sacrificed, families torn apart, futures shattered by war.

As she placed a foot on the train's metal stairs, she was sure she could hear the painter whispering a melancholy warning. Like the million-plus Frenchmen who didn't return from Germany after the Great War, would the same fate befall the sisters?